

CAPTURED CREASES (Clockwise from left) Two mothers lavishing affection on their calves; elephants after their favourite jackfruit; hand and trunk

revealing a yin-yang circle—a metaphor of balance in nature itself.

The book is not merely about visual splendour, it is also about insight—field intelligence distilled into art. Bedi captures the torment tuskers face during the period of *musth*; reproductive behaviour, calves being born. There are descriptions of observed behaviour; the coded sounds of elephant communication, signs of body language and complex social dynamics.

In its final section, the book turns elegiac. Bedi's lens follows the elephant into landscapes of loss—fragmented forests, encroaching highways and the underbelly of human progress. In an era when wildlife photography often chases viral moments, Bedi's elephant images ask us to slow down, to look longer, to recognise kinship. His work reminds us that the wild is not distant theatre, but a mirror of our own forgotten grace. With that gaze, Rajesh Bedi does not just photograph elephants—he consecrates them and makes them divine once more. ■

—Bandeep Singh

EXHIBITION ▼

Unfixing Meaning

IN HIS KOLKATA SHOWS, **PHOTOGRAPHER-PAINTER SOHRAB HURA** ABANDONS DOCUMENTARY REALISM

Sohrab Hura has returned to capturing momentum. His acclaimed photography, which brought global praise and membership to the prestigious Magnum Photos, shifted from capturing pace and intimacy to stoically documenting politics.

"The photography medium itself brings an idea of responsibility," Hura explains. "As the world keeps getting worse, my work grew more socially oriented. My photography got heavier. That's why I started to paint."

Hura's twin Kolkata exhibitions, backed by Experimenter, capture both ends of his work. *The Forest* at Experimenter's Ballygunge Place gallery (till Jan.3, 2026) has his pastels, gouaches and oil paintings. The Alipore Museum is hosting Hura's *A Winter Summer* (till Dec. 6), which marks the India debut of 'The Song of Sparrows in a Hundred Days of Summer (2013-2017)', shot in Madhya Pradesh, and 'Snow (2015-2019)' from Kashmir. While *The Forest* shows Hura's irreverence with a new medium, *A Winter Summer* shows his documentarian side.

A curious zoom-in, zoom-out effect is at work through the five-room arrangement for *The Forest*. Intimate moments with loved ones exist with memories from watching TV, pop-culture memes and events in political history. His short film *Disappeared*, debuting in India, exemplifies the modus operandi: beginning with an extreme zoom-in into a forest tent, until a massive zoom-out exposes the vast landscape.

"Everyone encountering an exhibition starts off stiff and sceptical," Hura explains. "The idea is to disarm them, make them move within the exhibition space, have them linger, as they close in on a work to catch some detail but soon experience the world in its entirety."

For instance, alongside tender paintings of lovers' hands brushing against one another, or his father having a smoke, there are wry observations at parties—where couples are getting intimate with comically varying degrees of interest.

Altogether, Hura is destabilising meaning. "Meanings today are so fixed," he says. "We artists should unfix meanings. If meanings are a still pond, we ought to throw a pebble at it, create a ripple and observe the edges far from the centre. If my photography earlier was about packing meaning, my work now is about unpacking." ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

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SHIFTING GEARS 'Glorious Sunset', gouache on paper and (below) 'Timelines', acrylic, gesso on cardboard box